

The Thoughts and Opinions

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1 The Truths

1.1 On Value, Compensation, and Self-Respect

Accepting lower pay despite high qualifications is not humility; it is economic self-sabotage.

When a highly capable person chooses to work for less, they do more than undermine their own worth—they pull down the market value of everyone with similar skills. Employers are quick to conclude that expertise, education, and years of effort can be bought at a discount. Your personal frugality, discipline, or investment habits are irrelevant to the value of your labour. Compensation should reflect capability, not your ability to stretch a rupee.

By settling for less, you are not only compromising your own trajectory but also lowering the professional standard for your entire field. You owe it to yourself—and to your peers—to maintain the market benchmark. Your financial philosophy may favour simplicity, but income negotiation is not the place for ascetic quotes or minimalist reasoning.

Your expertise deserves recognition. The market treats people the way they treat themselves; do not put a discounted price tag on your own labour.

1.2 On Financial Skill and the Illusion of “Managing With Less”

The ability to multiply a resource does not justify being given only a tiny resource.

What stays with me is this: I am exceptionally skilled at finance. Even with a modest income, I can optimize, save, invest, and grow wealth. I can stretch a rupee further than most. But that does not mean I deserve to receive only a few rupees.

I watch others earning three or four times more—70,000, 1 lakh—wasting money, mismanaging wealth, and still ending up ahead solely because they started with more. Not because of discipline or intelligence, but because volume often trumps efficiency. Optimizing money is not peaceful work; it is constant planning, mental labour, sacrifice, and self-control. My ability to create value from little should amplify my income, not limit it.

It is not meritocratic for an efficient person to be confined to survival-level pay. My skill in wealth creation should be applied to larger numbers, not used as an excuse to keep me small. The person who can thrive with less deserves more—not because they need it, but because they can use it better.

My frugality is not a discount code for my labour. My discipline is not an excuse to underpay me. Contentment is a virtue, but it is not a salary. I deserve the freedom to choose more, even if I do not rely on more.

1.3 The Strength of Thriving With Less

Those who learn to function with scarcity become unstoppable when given abundance.

People who grow up managing limited income or limited time develop a sharper discipline than those who always had enough. Scarcity builds intentionality. It forces prioritization, structure, and reliability. Someone who studies for only one hour a day—yet still succeeds—has mastered discipline more meaningfully than someone who had eight carefree hours.

This pattern repeats across life: individuals who grew up cutting corners and sacrificing comforts often develop the mindset that later lets them thrive with abundance. Their tolerance for error is low, their planning is precise, and their execution becomes dependable. Ironically, the busiest people are often the most reliable; they have learned to respect their own time.

If you can thrive with less, you will excel when finally given more.

1.4 On Wealth, Sharing, and Companionship

There is no point in having plenty of cake if you have no one to share it with.

Prestige means nothing without people. Even God, in scripture, did not walk alone—He had disciples, friends, and companions. The greatest failure is not poverty, but isolation. It is better to have a few loyal people by your side at the moment of suffering than to stand alone in a grand palace.

Authority should not be used to push others away. The divine figures of history all had true companions; humanity was never meant to flourish in solitude. Give generously. If you have bread, break it and share it. Wealth is hollow without fellowship.

1.5 On Caution, Thinking, and Life's Traps

The world is full of traps, and the naive are always the first to fall.

Life resembles a horror film: the unprepared, overly cheerful, or careless person is often the one caught first. Important decisions demand deep thought, analysis, and anticipation of every edge case. Even then, unexpected situations will arise. But disciplined thinking and long-term planning mitigate risk. If a trap cannot be avoided, learn to dismantle it. Life is not about escaping every problem; it is about learning to handle them with wisdom.

1.6 On Romance, Attachment, and Caution

Romance is not a priority—not because I lack desire, but because the cost seems to outweigh the reward.

Finding the right partner is difficult, and the search itself is costly—financially, mentally, and emotionally. Dating apps, matrimony sites, and past relationships have all led to connections that never grew into something meaningful. The emotional toll of a breakup is significant; it affects work, study, and peace of mind.

I am not against love, nor uninterested in marriage. I simply prioritize stability and compatibility. It is easier to naturally meet someone through work or study—places that allow consistent interaction—rather than artificially through platforms designed for quick matches. I desire a partner who is committed through life’s ups and downs, not someone who leaves at the first storm.

Until such a person appears, caution is wiser than reckless pursuit.

1.7 On Studying, Learning, and Mental Effort

Studying unfamiliar concepts is mentally expensive—and sometimes painful.

I do not love studying for its own sake. What makes mathematics enjoyable is that much of it builds on existing patterns in my mind. But when material becomes abstract or computationally heavy, studying becomes mundane and stressful. I prefer familiar territory. Even then, studying for more than three or four hours a day feels draining. Like a cheetah, I sprint only when necessary.

Learning something completely new often causes migraines, fatigue, and a sense of mental overload. New knowledge comes at a cost, and that cost is energy.

1.8 A Simple Truth About Envy

Sheldon Cooper will always envy Leonard's practicality; Leonard will always envy Sheldon's theoretical brilliance.

Some comparisons are eternal, humorous, and true.

1.9 On Faith and Fear

I tried to disprove Christ—and when I failed, the evidence pointed toward God, and I felt real fear.

Some truths reveal themselves not when we seek comfort, but when we seek contradiction. And sometimes, what we discover humbles us.

1.10 On Skepticism, Caution, and Refusing Exploitation

I do not care if people think I am closing doors because of my skepticism. I have seen too many traps to take half measures.

My caution is not paranoia; it is pattern recognition. Every time I have grown complacent, I have paid the price. I have witnessed talented, educated people exploited by hollow businessmen who cannot solve an integral yet excel at stealing credit. I refuse to be the invisible engine behind someone else's glory. I refuse to be the Wozniak to another man's Jobs.

Like Doubting Thomas, I insist on evidence before trust. The margin for error is thin, and the margin for letting others out-leverage me is thinner. I would rather miss ten dubious opportunities than surrender my dignity to one parasite. I will collaborate only where my contribution is protected in structure, not merely in flattering words.

My labour, creativity, and intellectual effort deserve visibility, protection, and fair reward. I decide the terms on which I share my mind and my time. May those who labour eat from the fruits of their labour — including me.

1.11 On Breadth, Depth, and Building a T-Shaped Life

Breadth without depth is a plastic shield against a sword. Depth without breadth is a one-legged man in an arse-kicking contest. But together — breadth and depth — form a deadly combination.

A T-shaped career, built by combining smart work with hard work, is the most adaptable and resilient. I have moved from being a pure generalist toward specializing in mathematics, even though the diminishing returns are real. The intuition and structure I gain are worth the effort.

1.12 On Exams, Credentials, and Strategic Leverage

I will write the UGC-NET, GATE (MA), and as many other exams as possible. These scores serve two purposes: they open career pathways, and they give me objective proof of competency. With strong marks, no employer can lowball me on the basis of credentials.

Yet my belief in academia is not blind. The glamour of JRF fades when you realize the restrictions: one income stream, fixed responsibilities, and strict limitations on outside work. It can feel like stepping into a box — unless you choose your supervisor wisely.

I still want a PhD, especially in mathematics, but not at the cost of drowning in research for its own sake. I want stability without suffocation, intellectual growth without entrapment. I do not want my financial comfort to arrive only when I have white hair — or no hair at all.

The opportunity cost of a PhD is real: time, youth, energy, potential. “Doctor” is a beautiful title, but I will not sacrifice my soul to earn it. Still, a PhD from a strong institute — especially with JRF — provides lifelong credibility, stability, and negotiating power.

Perhaps the intelligent approach is this: Collect GATE/NET/JRF for leverage. Choose a supportive mentor. Pursue meaningful but manageable research. Build parallel income skills. Maintain mobility at all costs.

A flawed system can still be navigated — if done on your own terms.

1.13 On Specialization, Effort, and the Inevitability of Success

The world rewards generalists, but a specialist generalist is rare and powerful. If you work hard, you will likely succeed. If you work smart, you will likely succeed. If you work both hard and smart, success becomes inevitable.

If I were as brilliant as I wish, I might have bypassed the years of waiting, found my soulmate, and built wealth already. But some things come only with timing and divine permission. Many variables must align before desires manifest.

1.14 On Money, Liquidity, and Emergency Planning

Money is a problem. I have many goals, but most of my wealth is locked in stocks, deposits, and schemes. Liquid cash is embarrassingly scarce, and I cannot liquidate investments without losing leverage.

Family support protects me for now, but they will not be here forever. This comfort is temporary. I must use this privileged platform to build something resilient before the brutality of life arrives like a storm. Build the shelter before the rain, not after.

Not everyone has a safety net — I must not waste mine.

1.15 On Hyper-Optimization, Health, and Temporary Sacrifice

Hyper-optimization is a heavy burden: optimizing every rupee, minute, and calorie is mentally taxing. Yet this is the burden of someone building a foundation for an extravagant future — not just financially, but intellectually and spiritually.

My health is imperfect. I am learning to strengthen both mind and body. I am a wounded bird that can still fly but must heal before attempting a long journey. Once I stabilize my health, I can scale my work far more effectively.

1.16 On Worst-Case Analysis and Power Dynamics

I live on worst-case analysis — Big O notation applied to life. Before loving a woman, I ask: will she help me succeed twenty years from now, or will she derail my life? Before joining an employer, I ask: will this empower my freedom, or is it a prestige trap with hidden costs?

Power dynamics shape everything. A woman married into a hostile household, a PhD student trapped under an exploitative supervisor, or an employee entering a toxic institution — all lose leverage the moment they sign the papers.

Avoid games where the opponent owns the board.

Some traps are inevitable, forced by circumstance. In those cases, grit, patience, and strategic escape matter more than guilt.

1.17 On Sexual Decisions, Life Traps, and Irreversible Mistakes

One careless decision — like intimacy without protection — can sign both a birth certificate and the death certificate of your dreams. Many people lose simply because they enter games they can never win and realize it too late.

Identify what serves your long-term interest. Avoid commitments that destroy leverage. Choose only what you can survive.

1.18 On Navigating Traps Through Probabilistic Thinking

I see everything as a potential trap, not because I refuse to trust, but because I evaluate risk in probabilities. A person may be 80% trustworthy and 20% dangerous. I operate in spectra, not absolutes.

Even with this mindset, I still fall into unforeseen traps — but fewer than I otherwise would. The goal is not to avoid every trap (impossible), but to navigate them with awareness. Blindspots always exist, whether I acknowledge them or not.

1.19 On Human Limits, Faith, and Over-Optimization

The human body is not a deterministic machine. It is allowed to function imperfectly, chaotically, inefficiently. Low output is not failure. You are allowed to rest.

Once we find God, we must also trust Him — just as we trust ourselves. But constant optimization eventually yields diminishing returns. Searching too hard for problems can create them. Not every fear is prophecy.

Just because loved ones will die someday does not mean we must mourn them prematurely.

1.20 On Light, Discernment, and Trust in God

I have found the light, and I know whom to call when I am lost. That does not mean others share the same enlightenment. I trust my instincts because I trust in God — and that alignment grounds me in Truth.

1.21 On Faith, Meritocracy, Planning, Attraction, Industry Truths, and Economic Realities

I have wept for one man more than the others combined, and his name is Jesus Christ. That name has power, and you cannot deny it.

I thought I could disprove God, but the more research I did — the more I studied testimonies, historical records, and artifacts — the more I realised that trying to disprove Jesus is like trying to disprove the Pythagoras theorem. Whenever I attempt to prove or disprove something I believe, I go in unapologetically, searching ruthlessly for a flaw. But this time, my mind was shocked. For the first time, I felt real fear while studying, because I knew I could not disprove it. The evidence held. My mind was the greatest sword I had, and it shattered like glass when confronting the Lord.

I am a firm believer in meritocracy. If the world were truly meritocratic, we would have far more progress and order. Unfortunately, most people do

not have equal starting points or systems, so a pure meritocracy is difficult to achieve.

As Warren Buffett said: *“If you don’t figure out how to make money while you sleep, you will have to work until you die.”*

Health is wealth — and sometimes, wealth is also health.

If you sense that your support system, comfort, or lifestyle may weaken, start planning immediately. Extract maximum value from limited resources. Leverage networks and free facilities. You will need to make sacrifices for a good life, and many of those sacrifices will feel painful or illogical at first. If academics begin to overload you, reduce intensity; the same applies to work and other responsibilities.

On Compatibility and Romantic Choices

The secret to attracting good women is to stop chasing the popular ones and start focusing on the compatible ones. Any man can look like a “player” if he only interacts with women whose culture, values, and temperament match his own. Compatibility creates attraction; incompatibility destroys it.

Use common sense and experience: identify which women are likely to say “yes” and which will clearly say “no.” Not everything requires heavy analysis. Gut feeling, after spending real time with a person, is usually a reliable guide.

A traditional Kerala-born man is far more likely to attract someone with similar cultural grounding. Compatibility is the biggest predictor of acceptance or rejection.

If you truly want a good partner, stop looking only at beauty and start looking for someone who complements you and aligns with your life direction.

On Research, Corporate Life, and Practical Income

Research has a high pay-to-effort ratio in terms of intellectual satisfaction, but corporate jobs pay more financially — and often bring more stress. If you want low-stress income, research, tutoring, and lecturing are among the easiest forms of money, provided you are actually skilled in those subjects.

Prestige does not pay bills. Srinivasa Ramanujan died poor. Nikola Tesla died poor. They are legends in academia but made little money in life.

“Learning something totally new in depth is an expensive endeavor — financially, mentally, and physically.”

Industry Realities: Twelve Observations

1. **The Real Money vs. The Glamour** “Most industries survive not because of the glamorous product you see, but because of hidden revenue streams that nobody talks about.” “The public face of a business is designed to look impressive; the actual profit machinery underneath is usually dull, practical, and embarrassingly simple.”
2. **Airlines** “Airlines don’t make money flying planes; they make money selling loyalty, points, credit-card partnerships, and extra fees. The flight is the spectacle — the profit is everything attached around it.”
3. **Fast Food** “McDonald’s is not a burger company. It’s a global real-estate corporation that uses burgers as a way to keep tenants paying rent.”
4. **Cinema Business** “Movie theatres don’t profit from cinema. They profit from snacks. The film pulls you in — the popcorn pays the electricity bills.”
5. **Gaming Consoles** “Console companies often lose money selling the hardware. The real payoff comes from locking users into an ecosystem of games, subscriptions, and accessories.”
6. **Tech Industry Reality** “The tech industry markets itself as a paradise of high salaries and innovation, but workers often experience it as unstable, high-pressure, and transactional, with none of the long-term security it promises.” “Modern software jobs look prestigious from the outside, but internally they function more like temporary contracting: high stress, low stability, and benefits that evaporate the moment the project ends.”

7. **Academia** “Academic research rarely pays the bills. Prestige, publications, and patents open doors — but the real income often comes from teaching, tutoring, guest lectures, and consulting.” “In academia, intellectual output builds reputation, but day-to-day financial survival comes from the practical work of educating others.”
8. **AI and High-Tech Monetization** “Modern AI companies operate on enormous computational costs, and most users never pay. The intelligence is impressive, but the revenue model is still trying to catch up.” “People assume AI companies are gold mines, but in reality the compute expenses dwarf the income. Brilliance is expensive, and most of the world wants it for free.”
9. **Social Media** “Social media platforms don’t sell apps; they sell attention. You’re not the customer — you’re the inventory being rented out to advertisers.”
10. **The Hidden Financial Engine** “What looks classy or futuristic on the surface is often powered by very old, very ordinary business models in the background.” “The shiny part of a company is usually the least profitable. The boring part — the leases, the licenses, the fees — is where the real money sits.”
11. **Job Market and Compensation** “Very few jobs pay people in proportion to the stress or value of their work; prestige often pays less, and mundane roles often pay more reliably.” “Stability and fairness are rare luxuries in modern work. Many careers reward constant burnout, while the most stable paths are the ones society rarely praises.”
12. **The Big Picture** “We live in a world where the appearance of money is glamorous, but the actual making of money is practical, unromantic, and often invisible.” “Business success usually comes not from brilliance or beauty, but from understanding where the real, steady income comes from — even if that income source looks boring or unimpressive.” “Prestige creates illusions. Profit comes from details.”

On Demand, Degrees, and Real Purchasing Power

Academic gatekeeping is real. Not just in research — everywhere. You are a fool if you believe degrees do not matter. What pays money is not desperation or interest, but **willingness to pay**.

Being rare or needed is irrelevant when nobody is willing to pay for what you offer.

Demand without money is not demand. A person may desperately want a tablet or a car, but if they are unwilling to pay the actual price, their interest is economically meaningless.

When searching for a job or building a business, analyse willingness to pay, not hype or rarity.

A café in a city with frugal customers will fail if priced too high. An AI startup will fail in a market where people want AI but will not pay for AI.

Most people spend on food, petrol, utilities — the unglamorous necessities. These sectors quietly outperform many “fancy” fields.

If a street vendor or bank manager earns more than a postdoc, do not foolishly chase the postdoc unless you genuinely want long-term academic identity and stability.

Teaching repetitive subjects may feel “low level” for a specialist, but it often pays better than research.

On Income, Pride, and Harsh Reality

If you want to make money, be prepared to set aside some dignity and the craving for a LinkedIn-worthy job title. Most high-paying work is not glamorous.

In India especially, many AI scientists make less than successful school principals. Most AI professionals earn money from sources not directly tied to their research.

The world rewards what people are willing to pay for — not what is intellectually beautiful.

2 The Haunted Academic

2.1 The Weight of Comparison

How many more degrees must I pursue? How high must my CGPA rise? How many papers, algorithms, or qualifications must I create and collect before I can finally look back at my old classmates and say:

“You underestimated me. You were wrong about me.”

How much more must I study before I can look at the professors who doubted me and say:

“Back then I couldn’t design an antenna, a VLSI block, or even a full adder. Today, it is child’s play.”

How tall must the stack of my work become — papers, ideas, contributions — before I can turn to those who dismissed me and say:

“Your talent does not intimidate me anymore. My discipline will outlast you.”

2.2 The Pain of Early Failure

During my engineering days, I sacrificed nights, sleep, and sanity. I studied until my mind shut down, yet nothing seemed to make sense. I could not code on a microprocessor. I could barely build a half adder. I sat alone in my hostel room, pushing my mind as far as it would go.

Meanwhile, others — privileged, carefree, insulated — spent their semesters partying, travelling, flirting, and wasting time. And somehow, they scored higher than me.

It hurt in ways I still struggle to articulate. I worked until exhaustion. They barely tried. Yet they walked away with the grades.

The injustice carved itself into my memory. It made me bitter. It made me furious. It made me question my worth.

2.3 The Rage That Remains

How far must I climb academically and financially before I can finally turn around and say:

“You were wrong. You were wrong about me then, and you are wrong about me now. I will fight for decades if I must, until my discipline eclipses your casual talent.”

How high must my tower of skill, knowledge, and intellect rise before I can face those classmates who outperformed me effortlessly and declare:

“You had fun and succeeded. I sacrificed everything and almost failed. But not anymore. My discipline beats your talent now — any day, every day.”

They laughed when I struggled. They mocked my slow understanding. They believed I was behind them.

But I was not behind — I was building.

I could not code a graph algorithm back then. I could not write Dijkstra from scratch. I could not solve a Bode plot without panic. But that is no longer true.

2.4 The Oath

I am not pathetic anymore. I am not weak anymore. I am not the confused boy they laughed at in class.

“You were wrong for judging my intelligence. You were wrong for dismissing my potential.”

They spent semesters fooling around while I studied until my eyes blurred, and they still scored higher.

I will never forget that humiliation. Not out of vengeance, but out of resolve.

One day, I will look them in the eye and say:

“You were wrong. You won back then — but not anymore. My discipline outlasts your talent. My effort outgrows your ease. You will not overshadow me again.”

I will keep building, keep sharpening, keep rising — until the shadows they put me in no longer exist.

2.5 Before the Ascent: The Boy I Used to Be

I am, in many ways, the least expected person to pursue higher education, let alone dream of a PhD or a life in academia. Nobody — not even I — saw this path coming.

Back in my engineering days (and this is an oversimplification, because my school years held their own share of serious and traumatic relationships), I had taken to someone. We were close, and I began planning a life far too early — the kind of life a teenager imagines before he understands the cost of being an adult.

Truthfully, I never wanted even a bachelor’s degree. If not for social pressure, I might have run away during 10th or 12th grade with a girl I loved. Academics were never my passion; only survival and common sense made me accept engineering. I knew I needed skills, leverage, and income if I wanted a life worth living.

My entire plan was simple, almost childish:

Study quickly. Get a job quickly. Earn just enough. Marry the girl I loved. Live happily ever after.

That was the whole dream — a TV-series family life, soft, peaceful, romantic. Not research. Not academia. Not ambition. Just love, stability, and escape.

Of course, reality had other plans.

The relationship fell apart easily, not because either of us was wicked, but because it was built on puppy love — beautiful, intoxicating, and completely devoid of structure or logic. A fantasy attempting to masquerade as a future.

And when it collapsed, the truth hit me with force:

Falling in love is a trap if you have no career, no stability, and no solid ground to stand on.

My dream of running away with her — to Hawaii, to a beach, anywhere far away — would have turned into a disaster in real life. Had that plan succeeded, I would have become a father long before I learned how to take care of myself. I would have been trapped in a marriage built on infatuation, not compatibility or preparedness.

So yes — in hindsight — the collapse of that fantasy was a mercy I did not recognise then.

Even now, I sometimes revisit that old escape in my imagination, but only as a simulation — never as a plan. Not until every piece of my life is aligned, not until I am stable, mature, and capable of building something real.

There was a time when I mocked my own lack of romantic experience the same way the fox mocked the grapes in the fable — calling it “sour” because he could not reach it.

But now I understand:

The grapes were never sour. I simply was not ready.

It is the same reason a ten-year-old cannot ride a motorcycle — not because he is unworthy, but because doing so would cause more damage than joy.

Some things must be waited for. Some things must be earned. And some things — especially love — require a foundation I simply did not have then.

3 Internship Experiences

3.1 Reliance Jio: The First Glimpse Into Industry

Both of my internships revolved heavily around Python and its rich ecosystem of data-science libraries. Although I eventually pivoted toward academia, my first real exposure to industry took place during the second year of my engineering degree, at Reliance Jio Headquarters in Navi Mumbai — a name large

enough to impress any recruiter, but the work itself was far more grounded and technical than the corporate gloss suggests.

My primary task involved analysing data collected from a smart plug. More specifically, I worked on power-consumption data from washing machines. The idea was elegant:

Detect when a device requires maintenance purely from its power-usage patterns.

The software pipeline existed for other appliance categories, but washing machines still needed a robust anomaly-detection system. An anomaly here meant any reading that deviated significantly from the machine's typical behaviour — a clue toward malfunction, power surge, or internal damage.

My first step was simple but essential: visualize the time-stamped data and look for irregular surges. Among the four machines we monitored, one clearly behaved abnormally. Its power signatures were subtly distorted, and it became the anchor for my modelling work.

3.1.1 DBSCAN and Its Limitations

At my supervisor's suggestion, I first explored DBSCAN — *Density-Based Spatial Clustering of Applications with Noise*. It worked reasonably well and detected several anomalies automatically, but it struggled with certain edge cases and lacked the flexibility I needed.

So I pivoted.

3.1.2 Designing My Own Algorithm

I wanted to create something from scratch — not just apply an existing method. I realised that the “normal” behaviour of the washing machine settled into an elliptical cluster when projected into a suitable statistical-feature space. The mathematics of fitting an exact ellipse was tedious, so I designed a heuristic based on:

- ratios of major and minor axes,

- Euclidean distances,
- and weighted statistical parameters.

This light-weight model worked astonishingly well. Despite the noisy and limited dataset, it reached an accuracy of about **96%**, outperforming both DBSCAN and the neural network I later built.

3.1.3 The Autoencoder Experiment

For completeness, I also implemented an autoencoder neural network — a model that learns the “shape” of normal behaviour and flags deviations. Due to the data scarcity and the complexity of the architecture, the autoencoder hovered around **68%** accuracy.

The custom algorithm remained my proudest contribution. It was efficient, interpretable, and creative — and more importantly, it **went into production testing**. For a 19-year-old intern, seeing one’s work integrated into the real pipeline was an unforgettable validation.

3.2 CSIR-NIO: Listening to the Ocean

In my third year of engineering, I transitioned from the private sector to a government research environment: CSIR-NIO (National Institute of Oceanography), Headquarters in Dona Paula, Goa. Another prestigious name — different world, different expectations.

The project was deceptively simple in description yet technically demanding:

Use marine bioacoustic recordings to study biodiversity in coral reefs.

We had **86 GB of raw audio data** — hours of fish sounds, ship noise, motor disturbances, and environmental static. But we could do nothing until we identified the frequency bands associated with the various fish species. Divers collected field data; fisherfolk shared traditional ecological knowledge; gradually we pieced together the sound-signature map.

Once we had those frequency ranges, the work became a pipeline:

1. Filter out noise from boats, ships, and machinery.
2. Apply Fast Fourier Transforms (FFT) to convert time-domain audio into frequency spectra.
3. Extract features used commonly in audio-classification tasks.
4. Compare patterns across different coral reefs.

The results were striking. Healthy reefs exhibited rich and complex sound signatures — proof of biodiversity, activity, and ecological balance. Dead or damaged reefs, by contrast, were sonically barren: little more than mechanical noise, with barely any life detectable.

We later analysed specific bandwidths to identify species such as snapping shrimp, prawns, crabs, and various coastal fish. The ocean, once transformed into frequencies and plots, told a clear story.

I was **20 years old** during this internship — old enough to understand the weight of scientific responsibility, young enough to still feel the awe of discovery.

3.3 A Dual Foundation

Between Reliance Jio and CSIR–NIO, I had built a résumé that stood out among my peers. Most classmates had one notable internship; I had two — one from a major private conglomerate, and another from a premier government research institute.

More importantly, I carried with me something greater than certificates:

- the confidence of solving a real engineering problem from scratch,
- the discipline of analysing massive datasets,
- the humility of working with nature’s complexity,
- and the understanding that knowledge can be applied at every scale — from washing machines to coral reefs.

Those internships marked the beginning of a long journey — one that would eventually lead me away from industry and deeper into academia.

4 On Performance-Based Work and the Cost of Exploitation

I am a cautious man by nature — skeptical, analytical, and deliberate — even if, in certain aspects of life, I appear bold or audacious. This caution shapes the way I think about work, compensation, and the traps embedded within modern employment systems.

4.1 Why I Reject Performance-Based Pay

I am firmly, unapologetically against performance-based pay. Perhaps I am biased, but my reasons are valid. To me, performance pay is not an incentive — it is a trap. If a company offers both fixed and performance-linked pay, I will refuse the latter without hesitation.

I will not allow my ability to feed myself or my future family to depend on output, productivity, or performance metrics designed to squeeze me dry. I refuse to be treated like a machine optimised for maximum output and minimum cost.

Many companies use a subtle strategy:

Extract as much potential as possible while maintaining the lowest possible salary expenditure.

I will not participate in that game. Henry Ford’s strategy of “double the work for double the pay” does not fool me. It might work on workers who are desperate, but I am not desperate — I am aware. Linear rewards for exponential effort is not a bargain; it is exploitation dressed as opportunity.

4.2 The Fear of Becoming Someone Else’s Pawn

My skepticism is not limited to industry. It extends to academia, friendships, relationships — everything. I have seen too many brilliant minds reduced to

pawns by people far less capable than them.

Nikola Tesla died in a hotel room, impoverished, unprotected, while businessmen who lacked even a fraction of his brilliance profited from his ideas.

I refuse to be the technical genius powering someone else's empire while they take the credit — the way Steve Wozniak powered Apple while the world worshipped Steve Jobs.

I am not greedy for money. I am greedy for my time, my energy, and my peace. And anything that drains my energy is something I will avoid unless absolutely necessary — and even then, I will look for an exit.

4.3 The Right to be Protected, Even at My Lowest

Performance pay pays you the most when you already need it the least. It pays the least exactly when life is crushing you — when you are sick, broken, burnt out, grieving, or hospitalized.

I need money *when I am failing*, not only when everything is going well. A company that values me only at my peak is no different from a trophy wife who is present in success but absent in hardship.

If an organisation cannot value me in my lows, then I will not commit to it in my highs.

4.4 The Need for Leverage

To protect myself, I must build leverage — credentials, reputation, expertise, and bargaining power. If people will not treat me fairly voluntarily, I must construct a profile that forces them to.

The more leverage I have, the less vulnerable I am to politics, corporate agendas, or manipulative managers.

4.5 Seeing Through the Illusion of Success Stories

When I look at Tesla (the company), I do not see success; I see a research project built by engineers, later acquired and branded by Elon Musk — while the original creators remain obscure.

When I look at Apple, I do not see the genius of Steve Jobs alone; I see the brilliance of Steve Wozniak overshadowed by the charisma of a businessman.

When I look at Edison and Tesla, I see a pattern:

Businessmen winning. Scientists losing.

I refuse to be part of that legacy.

4.6 Walking Through Life Like a Minefield

I navigate life through the lens of Big-O notation — not the best case, not the average case — but the worst case.

While others walk through life as if strolling in a garden, I walk as if through a minefield. Every interaction is a potential trap. Every smile or compliment may contain a hidden motive. Every opportunity must be examined like an algorithm with unknown edge cases.

This is not paranoia; it is calibrated caution — skepticism just below the threshold of delusion.

I remember every red flag, even if I choose to forgive. And the moment I sense someone trying to exploit me, I begin planning my escape.

4.7 The Refusal to Sell My Soul

I have seen enough:

- Jack Ma openly regretting his family life.
- Jeff Bezos and Bill Gates failing to sustain peaceful marriages.
- Elon Musk disowned by his own children.

They gained the world and lost themselves. They sold their soul for empire.

I refuse to follow that path.

My peace, my time, and my energy are worth more than any performance-based pay cheque.

I will walk away from exploitation — whether it comes disguised as opportunity, prestige, innovation, or ambition.

I have one life. I will not spend it as someone else's optimised machine.